# AD TO REDEMPTION




**MARCH IS THE MESSAGE**
West Bengal minister Chandrima Bhattacharya (third from left) with other TMC women leaders at a village in Murshidabad district

grassroots-level officials at villages and blocks are under public surveillance. "The teacher's recruitment scam has made things difficult. People don't believe us even if a genuine bottleneck in the release of funds delays panchayat work. They are mobbing our houses and branding us as thieves," says a panchayat samiti member of Ausgram in Bardhaman. Other leaders, too, admit that people are emboldened now to demand their due. "We are being held accountable. The general belief is that TMC leaders have made money by looting the common man. Even those like us who live a humble life face uncomfortable questions about the lifestyle of some leaders. After the arrests of Parthada and Anubratada (TMC's Birbhum strongman Anubrata Mondal), we could not meet people. They made fun of us," says another TMC leader. It's this state of affairs the TMC wants to correct.

**THE TMC HAS BEEN FORCED TO HIT THE ROADS AS THE LEFT HAS BEEN STEADILY HOLDING IT ACCOUNTABLE FOR, AMONG OTHER THINGS, UNFINISHED PROJECTS**

All this has come after a renewed burst of activism from the Left. Hundreds of its roadshows and rallies pointed to gross inequities in society: thousands of educated, unemployed youth against jobs being sold at a premium (as in the alleged scam), the poor living on doles juxtaposed with the jaw-dropping affluence of even local-level politicians and so on. Naturally, it has struck a chord with people.

In a desperate attempt to weave a counter-narrative, Mamata has decided to deploy her women's brigade. Titled Cholo Gram-ey Jai (let's visit villages), the outreach programme is targeting women and using them to spread the good word about the TMC's governance. About 90 per cent of women in Bengal are beneficiaries of various government schemes. The basic monthly allowance of Rs 1,000 (for SCs/ STs) and Rs 500 (for others) under the Lakshmir Bhandar scheme has benefited 15 million women. Besides this, there is the Kanyashree stipend for 8 million girl students, cycles for girls (*saboojsathis*) and Swasthyasathi health cards for women. All this has helped create a loyal base of women voters for the TMC. A Lokniti-CSDS survey showed that in the 2021 assembly polls, while 46 per cent of the male vote went to TMC, as many as 50 per cent women voters supported Mamata. The TMC is politically indebted to women; in her hour of need, Mamata has now turned to them.

Under the Cholo Gram-ey Jai programme, members of TMC's women's wing have started spreading out across villages from November 1. The programme will last for two and a half months. Through informal meetings, they are engaging rural women. "We want them to air their grievances. The CM has asked us to check if all are getting their share under various schemes. Our teams will give them a hearing and ensure prompt redressal," says state finance minister Chandrima Bhattacharya, who is overseeing the outreach.

The Left seems equally keen to head off this counter. Its new programme, Adhikar Yatra (rights march), plans to reach out to the remotest of areas and raise awareness about basic livelihood issues, including wages of working class and poor people. Whether all this will bear political fruit during the panchayat polls remains to be seen. But one thing is clear: Bengal's parties can ignore the call of the open roads only at their peril. ■